# Negative

## By Joyce Carol Oates

*NOTE: For casting . . . . . Mary is Caucasian and Veronica is African-American*

## INTRODUCTION

*ACTRESS 1: After nearly 60 years of court-ordered integrated education, most Americans are aware of the problems of black students brought into a predominantly white school.*

*ACTRESS 2: But what happens when it is the other way around—when a few whites attend a black school?*

*ACTRESS 1: You see, many believe that a child is not born a racist, but rather racism is a learned social phenomenon, via family, education, religion, the law, and the media.*

*ACTRESS 2: And yet, It is difficult to grow up in society without adopting the worldviews and biases of the society.*

*ACTRESS 1: Joyce Carol Oates explores this phenomenon in her one-act: Negative.*

**MARY:** (A naive, childlike tone) So-this is it! At last! My freshman room! Oh God I'm so excited I can't stand it! The college of my choice-my dreams! And I'm here on a scholarship-they want me! (Pause, hugs herself) For months I've been dreaming of this moment and now I'm here-alone. My roommate's been here-and gone out again-we haven't met-my folks are driving back to Davenport and I'm-here-alone. (A touch of panic) (Pause) No. I am not scared. I am Mary Strep, Class of 1998. Whooeee! (Tiptoes over to examine her roommate's things.) Oh, God!-my roommate must be rich. (Holds a stylish leather mini-skirt against herself; stares into mirror) Wow. (Holds up a dressier costume; sighs) Oh!-so pretty. (She discovers a framed photograph of Veronica and her family which she stares at, appalled.) Oh!-oh no. Oh no. The college has matched me with one of them. Veronica strides into the room with a dazzling smile. Very attractive, self-assured. A beat as Mary and Veronica stare at each other.

**VERONICA:** (Recovering first, exuding "personality") Well, hi! I'm Veronica Scott, your roommate!

**MARY:** Oh!-h-hi! (She has almost dropped the photograph; stammers guiltily} I was j-just admiring your f-family

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**VERONICA:** (Warmly extending her hand to shake Mary's) Please call me "Ronnie"-all my friends do.

**MARY:** (Shyly and awkwardly shaking hands, as if it's a new thing for her) "R-Ronnie"

**VERONICA:** "Veronica " is a nice enough name but far too formal, don't you think? I believe in informality. And what is your name?

**MARY:** My n-name?

**VERONICA:** Maybe it's on your name tag?

**MARY:** (Squinting down at the button) Oh yes-" Mary Strep."

**VERONICA:** Hmmm!- "Mary Strep." I like it.

**MARY:** (Faintly incredulous) You do?

**VERONICA:** Oh, yes! You don't hear many names like that. So-exotic. Musical. Is it a name with a legend?

**MARY:** My mother's name is " Mary," and so is my grandmother's " Mary." Back through my father's family everybody is named "Strep."

**VERONICA:** Fascinating! And where are all these people?

**MARY:** Huh?

**VERONICA:** Sorry, I mean where are you from, Mary?

**MARY:** Davenport, Iowa.

**VERONICA:** Ooooh no! You aren't! (Enunciates words sensuously) "Davenport, Iowa!"

**MARY:** What's wrong?

**VERONICA:** Nothing's wrong, it's just you're the first person from Davenport, Iowa, I've ever met.

**MARY:** Gosh, I'm sorry. . .

**VERONICA:** Oh, no-it's fabulous. "Davenport, Iowa." Such a wholesome cereal-sounding kind of place! (Pause, sighs) I'm from Greenwich, Connecticut: quintessence of American Suburbia.

**MARY:** "Greenwich, Connecticut"-I've heard of it, I think. It sounds beautiful. So-green?

**VERONICA:** And where did you go to high school, Mary?

**MARY:** (Surprised) In Davenport, Iowa.

**VERONICA:** Oh-there's a school there?

**MARY:** {Puzzled} Sure. Davenport High School.

**VERONICA:** (Catching on) Oh, I see!-public school. You went to public school-of course.

**MARY:** Where-did you go?

**VERONICA:** (Airily) Oh, Exeter. Eight members of our graduating class are here as freshmen; must be twenty-five Exeter grads on campus. Can't escape us!

**MARY:** Exeter must be an-exclusive school?

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**VERONICA:** Oooooh no! Not really. We had lots of scholarship students. Exeter is racially mixed, and balanced; two of my closest friends-and a roommate, junior year-were white girls. Really.

**MARY:** That's... nice.

**VERONICA:** (Proudly) The president of our senior class was a white boy.

**MARY:** Oh that's. . . nice.

**VERONICA:** And he was gay; and he had psoriasis. We all loved him. (Pause; rubbing hands together briskly) Well! Which corner of the room would you prefer, Mary? I was here earlier but I deliberately didn't choose, I thought I'd leave the choice to you.

**MARY:** To me?

**VERONICA:** Why, yes!-to you. That corner has the window, and that corner has the, um, corner.

**MARY:** (Shyly) Gosh, I-just don't know.

**VERONICA:** A view of the bell tower and the historic green where a climactic battle of the Revolutionary War was fought-or a view of the, um, corner?

**MARY:** (Very hesitantly pointing toward the window) Well-maybe-if you don't m-mind

**VERONICA:** My, thanks! (As if Mary has pointed in the reverse direction, Veronica takes the bed near the window; she speaks sincerely) Now you're sure, Mary? You don't mind not having the view, or any natural light?

**MARY:** (Swallowing) I guess not. . . Veronica.

**VERONICA:** (Shaking forefinger, big smile) Now, now-"Ronnie!" I'll call you " Mary,"-I adore that name!-if you'll call me "Ronnie." (Places a quilted spread on her bed as if to claim it) Now: the closets. Which is your preference, Mary?

**MARY:** (Squinting and groping about) It's sort of . . . dark. . . over here. I don't see a closet.

**VERONICA:** The big, spacious one is back beyond your desk; the absurdly cramped one is over here by mine. But please feel free to choose whichever you wish.

**MARY:** Oh, now I see it! (Opens closet door) Gee, it is spacious.

**VERONICA:** Obviously, I have many more clothes and suitcases than you do, Mary, but-it's your choice.

**MARY:** (Apologetically) It probably makes sense for me to take this one, Ronnie, doesn't it?-since it's

**VERONICA:** (Sharply) What'd you call me, girl?

**MARY:** "R-Ronnie"

**VERONICA:** Oh, right-I guess I told you to call me "Ronnie." (Slightly forced smile) If we're going to be roommates I suppose it's best to be informal. (Tapping foot impatiently) Take your time choosing, Mary. We've got all afternoon.

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**MARY:** (Shyly) Well, like I said it probably makes sense for me to take this closet, since it's right beside my

**VERONICA:** (Now a sincere dazzling smile) Oh, that's sweet of you,

**MARY:** -thanks.

Again Veronica behaves as if Mary has said exactly the reverse of what she has said. Veronica begins to hang up her clothes in the larger closet; Mary has no choice but to hang up her clothes in the other closet.

**VERONICA:** We'll have dinner together, Mary, O.K.? You can join me and my friends from Exeter-and these really cool guys I just met. Unless you have other plans?

**MARY:** (Quickly) Oh no, no-I don't know anyone here. It's such a big place and I-I don't know anyone here.

**VERONICA:** (Squeezing Mary 's hand) Well, you know me.

As Mary goes to hang up a dress, Veronica pauses to admire it effusively. It is a quite ordinary plaid wool dress with a white bow, white cuffs.

**VERONICA:** Ooooh! What is this?

**MARY:** (Shyly) My good wool dress. . .

**VERONICA:** Where'd you find such a style?

**MARY:** My grandma sewed it for me. For my eighteenth birthday just two weeks ago.

**VERONICA:** No! Your grandmother sewed this?- (Making a sewing gesture as if plying a needle) -by hand?

**MARY:** Oh, no, Grandma uses a sewing machine-a Singer. She's had the same identical machine since 1938.

**VERONICA:** My grandmothers, they insist we grandchildren call them "Meredith" and "Tracey"-their first names. They look young as my mother. (Laughs) They'd as soon run a sewing machine as a-butter churn. I'm envious! (Holding Mary's dress against herself, admiring)

**MARY:** (Proudly) Actually, Grandma sews all my clothes. She sewed these. (Indicating the nondescript outfit she is wearing.)

**VERONICA:** Isn't that sweet! Soooo caring! Must be a folkway, or some thing? In Indiana?

**MARY:** (Shyly) What's a-folkway?

**VERONICA:** (Airily intellectual) Oh, just some species of unexamined ethnic, religious, or regional custom aborigines persist in practicing over the centuries without a clue as to why. Claude Levi-Strauss is still the most insightful analyst of the phenomenon. (Preening before mirror) You see, Mary, when you wear this, um, most original dress your grandmother sewed for you, you feel happy because you feel loved. That's a folkway.

**MARY:** Oh. (Wipes at eyes) Gosh, I'm going to m-miss Grandma-so far away!

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**VERONICA:** You see?-emotion of a primitive, visceral, binding nature is generated out of, um, not much. (Examining dress, tums a sleeve roughly inside out) How's this sewed together?-oh! (She has ripped a seam) (Sincerely) Gee, I'm sorry, Mary.

Mary tries to take the dress from Veronica but Veronica retains it.

**MARY:** (Childlike, accusing) You ripped the seam, Veronica. . .

**VERONICA:** It was an accident, Mary. I said I was sorry.

**MARY:** You tugged at it, I saw you.

**VERONICA:** I did not tug, I was just looking. The thread is rotted-see? (Tugs slightly, and another seam rips) That's the cause.

Mary takes the dress from Veronica, staggering to her side of the room; contemplates the dress; hangs it in the closet. Veronica has located a camera amid her possessions, and approaches Mary.

**VERONICA:** Mary?-turn here!

Mary turns, and Veronica takes a quick flash photo.

**MARY:** (A bit blinded) W-What did you do that for?

**VERONICA:** (A bit evasively) Um-just wanted to. I'm sentimental. This being our first day together, and all. (Pause, warmly) Mary, I know! I'll have your dress mended by this wonderful French seamstress who sews my Momma's clothes. She can replace all that rotted old thread with new. And, um, maybe straighten the hemline. . .

**MARY:** (Quickly) No, thanks-I'll take the dress home at Thanksgiving, and Grandma can mend it herself. She'd want to.

**VERONICA:** I just hope these quaint old Midwestern folkways don't die out before Thanksgiving!

**MARY:** (Coolly) If you mean my Grandma Crockett, she's only eighty-three years old. Her mother is still alive and going strong with her Singer sewing machine-(Proudly) -at the age of one hundred and one.

**VERONICA:** (Genuinely amazed) No! You actually have a great-grand mother, Mary?-one hundred one years old?

**MARY:** Great-grandma Quantril is my younger great-grandmother, in fact.

**VERONICA:** Ooooh! I just have to record this! (She has located a tape recorder amid her possessions; slips in a cassette, sets the machine going) You say, Mary, you have two great-grandmothers?-and how many grandmothers?

**MARY:** (Staring at recorder) W-What is that?

**VERONICA:** Oh, probably you don't have these in Indiana-don't pay the slightest heed.

**MARY:** You're-recording what I say? R-right now?

**VERONICA:** I said-never mind me, you're the fascinating one of the two of us, Mary. Rich archival lore! (Mysteriously) I see I have much, much to learn this freshman year. Now, about the grandmothers

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**MARY:** (A bit stiffly) I'd rather not discuss my grandmothers any more right now, thanks. "Ronnie."

**VERONICA:** Oh, but think of those old pioneer women out there on the great cereal plains of America-sewing away. Gives me the shivers!

**MARY:** Actually... Davenport is a city.

**VERONICA:** "Davenport"-what's that?

**MARY:** Where I'm from-Davenport, Ohio. I mean-Iowa. It's a city, not a cereal field. (A bit boastful) We have a population of over one hundred thousand.

**VERONICA:** (Skeptical) People?

**MARY:** Yes...

**VERONICA:** (Catching on) Oh, you mean white people.

**MARY:** (Noticing tape recorder) Gosh, is that thing still on?

**VERONICA:** No! (Pretends to be switching the recorder off) There we are: off. (Teasing) My, we're a little thin-skinned, Mary, aren't we? That's how Davenportians are?

**MARY:** I'm s-sorry, it just makes me n-nervous

**VERONICA:** You know, Mary, your accent is so interesting. I've never heard one quite like it before.

**MARY:** My accent? (Veronica tries to hide her laughter.)

**MARY:** (Hurt) What's so f-funny?

**VERONICA:** Not a thing. I adore the way you talk, Mary! Look: America is a mosaic of many, many different ways of speech-local customs-"ac-cents"- (She cruelly imitates Mary's "accent")-it's a democracy and we're all equal.

**MARY:** We are?

Veronica stifles laughter again.

**MARY:** (Miserably) Everybody's going to laugh at me here-I know it. My professors, my classmates, my r-roommate-In my dreams, all summer, I'd hear strangers laughing at me-but I didn't know why.

**VERONICA:** (Practicably) Well, now you know. That's a gain.

**MARY:** Maybe you could h-help me, Ronnie? I could learn to talk like you?

**VERONICA:** (Graciously) I have no objections if you try to model yourself after me, certainly. My little, um, white-girl roommate at Exeter tried that, too. It was such fun.

**MARY:** What happened?

**VERONICA:** Oh, I don't know. We were just roommates a few weeks before she, um, dropped out of school. Vanished without a trace.

**MARY:** (Grimly) That's what I'm afraid of. Scared to death. I'll fail my subjects-drop out-vanish without a trace. Oh gosh-golly!

**VERONICA:** (Enunciating in the direction of the recorder) "Gosh-golly!"

**MARY:** (Upset) Is that recorder-thing still on?

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**VERONICA:** It is not. I told you I turned it off, didn't I?
**MARY:** Why is this little wheel still going round?
**VERONICA:** It's unwinding. Relax, Mary.
Mary would turn back to continue unpacking, but Veronica detains her. An initial shyness, or a pretense of shyness, on Veronica's part.
**VERONICA:** Oh, er. . . Mary? Now we've, um, gotten to know each other so well. . . can I ask you something personal?
**MARY:** (Guardedly) What?
**VERONICA:** Your hair.
**MARY:** (Touching hair, alarmed) My hair? That's a question?
**VERONICA:** I've always wanted to ask one of you: is your hair naturally that way? Or do you do something to it?
Veronica touches Mary's hair with cautious fingers; her expression is one of someone touching an insect.
**VERONICA:** SO sort of-fine. Dry. Ooooh!-sort of shivery.
**MARY:** (Backing off) I d-don't do anything to my hair except shampoo it.
**VERONICA:** Don't you brush it? Comb it?
**MARY:** (Hotly) Of course I brush and comb it! I just don't think about it.
**VERONICA:** (Faint protest) But your hair is-lovely, Mary. It suits you perfectly.
**MARY:** I-I'd better finish packing, I mean unpacking. . . (Fumblingly re tums to her things)
**VERONICA:** (Cheerfully) I'd better finish unpacking. We have a date for dinner, remember?-a big table of us. You'll love my friends, Mary. And I know they'll be crazy about you. (Pause)
Mary is so rattled she drops something; Veronica doesn't notice.
**VERONICA:** And these two guys I just met-are they cool.
Mary and Veronica are busily hanging up clothes, unpacking suitcases and boxes, etc.
**MARY:** (Worried) These guys, um-are they?
**VERONICA:** Seniors. Real hunks!
**MARY:** Are they, er-?
**VERONICA:** Good-looking? You bet!
**MARY:** I mean, um
**VERONICA:** Tall? For sure. I don't go out with dwarfs!
**MARY:** (Miserably nervous) I, er, was wondering what-r-r-race
**VERONICA:** (Surprised) "Race"-?
**MARY:** I mean, you know-what c-c-color-their skin
**VERONICA:** "Color?"-"skin?" (A beat.) I didn't notice.
**MARY:** Oh.
**VERONICA:** I never notice such superfluities. Race-skin--color: America is a mosaic, we're all absolutely equal, we're beyond primitive divisions of us and them.

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**MARY:** Yes, but I-I get n-nervous, if- I mean, I don't feel comfortable if- I had this feeling, when my folks and I crossed the quad, and came into the dorm here-p-people were watching us.

**VERONICA:** What kind of people?

**MARY:** The, uh-majority people. Your people.

**VERONICA:** Mary, that isn't so! Why'd anybody look at you? (Pause, embarrassed) Oh, um-I didn't mean that the way it sounded. I just meant-people like you are one hundred percent welcome here-this college has been integrated since 1978! Wasn't that a rousing speech the Chancellor gave this morning?- "Giving a Boost to The Needy." And you "Deficiency Scholars" aren't tagged in any obvious way; it's almost as if you scored high SATs and your folks can pay full tuition like the rest of us. Really. Roommates are warned-I mean, notified-but only so we can help tutor you, if necessary. I volunteered to room with one of you, for that purpose.

**MARY:** Gee, you did?

**VERONICA:** Well, it fits in with my Freshman Honors Seminar thesis.

**MARY:** (Stunned) You've chosen your topic already? What is it?

**VERONICA:** Um... a photo-journal account. Kind of a personal diary. With anthropological and psychological dimensions, of course.

**MARY:** You're going to write about. . . me?

**VERONICA:** Oh no, oh no!-don't be silly, Mary. Not you. Not you personally.

**MARY:** Now I feel kind of. . . funny.

**VERONICA:** Well, you wouldn't, if you didn't take everything so personally! (Pause) Just be yourself. Be your natural self. That's my philosophy of life.

**MARY:** (Swallowing hard) "Just be yourself." I'll try, Ver-, "Ronnie." Can I model myself after you?

**VERONICA:** Oooooh is that sweet! (Gives Mary a quick kiss on the cheek, which quite dazes Mary) But you should just be you, if you know who that is. That's what growing up in America in these enlightened times is all about.

Mary and Veronica continue unpacking, etc. Veronica removes her beanie and tosses it onto her bed; Mary, watching her, imitates her-but Mary's beanie misses her bed. Veronica whistles and moves to suggestive dance music; Mary imitates her, unable to do more than hiss, and moving about most clumsily.

**VERONICA:** Um- Mary?

**MARY:** (Eager, yet in dread) Y-Yes, "Ronnie?"

**VERONICA:** Could you do me a favor and carry this trunk downstairs to the storage room?

A beat.

**VERONICA:** (Radiant smile) I'll be happy to pay you, of course!

**MARY:** (Stunned) N-Now?

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**VERONICA:** Well, before dinner. Is five dollars enough?
**MARY:** I...
**VERONICA:** Ten dollars?
**MARY:** But I . . .
Veronica locates her wallet, takes out a ten-dollar bill, lays it on Mary's desk with a flourish.
**VERONICA:** Thanks so much, Mary. I appreciate it. (Pause) These suit cases, now-hmmm!-maybe they can fit into your closet?
**MARY:** S-Suitcases? Gosh, I don't think so
**VERONICA:** (Peering into Mary's closet, shoving clothes on hangers roughly aside) Well, we can try. C'mon, help me. (Veronica and Mary push several of Veronica's suitcases into the closet) Tight fit, but it's O.K. Thanks!
Some of Mary's shoes have been forced out of the closet; Mary, not knowing what to do with them, puts them beneath her bed. Veronica is unnoticing.
**MARY:** (Plaintively) But, Veronica, here are my own s-suitcases
**VERONICA:** You can take them down to the storage with you, along with my trunk. They're made of cardboard, not leather-they won't scratch. What's the problem? (Seems genuinely puzzled)
Mary covers her face with her hands. During this speech of Veronica's she goes into a trance, stares off into space.
**VERONICA:** (Shyly boastful) I didn't want to, um, overwhelm you right away, Mary, but. . . my father is Byron T. Scott. (Pause; no response from Mary, but Veronica behaves as if there is) Yes, that's right!-I'm the daughter of Byron T. Scott himself. (Pause) Daddy is in private practice in Manhattan now, but, in the Sixties, I guess you know, he was a renowned civil rights attorney. A personal friend of John F. Kennedy-and Jackie; and, now, Bill and Hillary. (Pause; no response from Mary, but Veronica behaves as if there is) Yes, I sure am lucky, Mary! And I know it. Daddy was a champion of integration from the first. In his law firm he always hired whites-not by quota, either. And the handicapped. (Pause) Physically and mentally challenged-Daddy doesn't discriminate, nor does he allow others to do so. Ooooh no! That's how we were brought up.
Veronica has tiptoed over to get her camera, unobtrusively.
**VERONICA:** (Lyric, sentimental) Mary, I want to share this with you. One of my earliest memories is of my nanny. . . who was white. (Pause) Nellie Fay Cotton, the kindly, obese, diabetic Ozark woman my parents hired at the minimum wage to care for me when I was just a baby. Ooooh did I love Nellie Fay! She was ugly as sin, and, ugh, the ugliest hair-but her soul was beautiful inside. (Pause) Nellie was of welfare stock-had fifteen children by the age of thirty-five-her husband was an unemployed miner with black lung who had

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nothing to do all day but drink and beat up on her till she finally escaped with her children and fled North-but Nellie never lost her faith in God-never! "The Lord sees into our hearts, He loves us each and every one"-Nellie used to tell me, when I was still in my crib. (Wiping at eyes, maudlin) Then, one summer when I was five or six, these sort of snooty relatives of Momma's were visiting, from Boston, and my aunt's sapphire choker was missing from her room, and Nellie Fay was the suspect of course, and oh! it was so sad!-Nellie Fay was scared and nervous and acted guilty-poor thing! The Greenwich police were called-interrogated Nellie down at the station-did a body check, I guess-didn't find the missing jewelry-but Nellie Fay was dismissed from our household, and went away, and a few days later guess what?

Veronica turns dramatically to Mary, who sits as before, staring glassily into space.

**VERONICA:** You guessed it, Mary!-the damn old choker was found in the deep end of our swimming pool, when the maintenance men came to clean it. Oh, were Momma and Daddy apologetic! Oh, were they chagrined! Right away they sent for Nellie Fay, but it was too late. Poor dear Nellie had killed herself-in shame-swallowed a can of Drano she'd taken out of our kitchen. Oh! the sorrow in our household! the regret! It took Momma weeks and weeks to find an adequate replacement! (Wipes at eyes; pause; she has the camera ready) Excuse me, Mary? Could you look up, and smile? I'd like an intimate shot of both of us. To commemorate our first day together as roommates. The frontispiece of my photo-joumal. . .

**VERONICA:** (Adjusts camera, positions it on a desk or table facing Mary) Now!-I set this here-set the timer-O.K.! (Hurries to get into the picture, sitting beside Mary on the bed; her arm around Mary's shoulders and her head close beside Mary's) One-two-three SMILE! We're going to have a terrific freshman year!

Veronica smiles her dazzling smile; Mary remains catatonic but smiles, at last, a ghastly blank wide smile.

Camera flashes.

Lights out.

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## SOURCE INFORMATION

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